

ARMADILLOS

Recognizable by their armoured shell – unique among mammals – armadillos occur in various shapes, sizes, and colours. All are native to the Americas.

Armadillos, sole members of the order Cingulata, range across a variety of habitats, feeding mostly on insects and other invertebrates. Despite having short legs, armadillos can run quickly and burrow with their strong claws to avoid predators. Their main defence consists of a bony carapace, covered with horny plates, across their upperparts. In most species, there are rigid shields over the shoulders and hips, with a varying number of bands separated by flexible skin covering the back and flanks. This allows some species to roll into a ball to protect their vulnerable, furry underparts.

Armadillos have few natural predators. Despite the threats from human hunters and habitat loss, the range of some armadillo species is expanding.

Although their armour is heavy, armadillos are effective swimmers. By inflating the stomach and intestines with air, they can increase their buoyancy and cross small bodies of water. Armadillos can hold their breath under water for several minutes, allowing them to walk over a stream bed rather than swim across it.

HABITS

Most species of armadillo are nocturnal, though they occasionally emerge during the day as well. These animals are largely solitary, associating with one another only during the mating season. Males sometimes display aggression towards rivals.

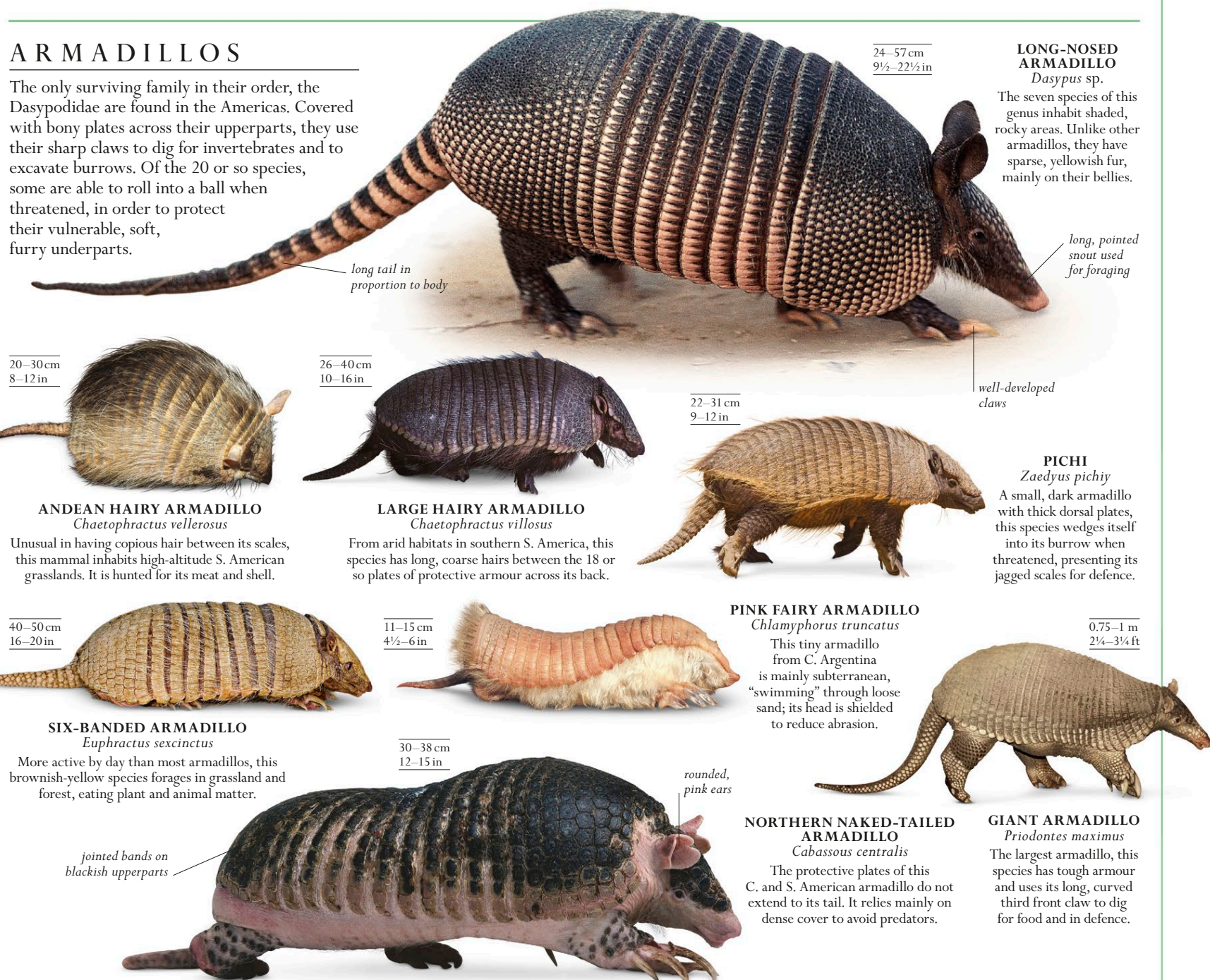
PHYLUM	CHORDATA
CLASS	MAMMALIA
ORDER	CINGULATA
FAMILIES	2
SPECIES	20



Contrary to popular belief, not all armadillos can roll into a ball in defence – only species of the genus *Tolypeutes* can.

ARMADILLOS

The only surviving family in their order, the Dasypodidae are found in the Americas. Covered with bony plates across their upperparts, they use their sharp claws to dig for invertebrates and to excavate burrows. Of the 20 or so species, some are able to roll into a ball when threatened, in order to protect their vulnerable, soft, furry underparts.



24–57 cm
9½–22½ in

LONG-NOSED ARMADILLO

Dasypus sp.

The seven species of this genus inhabit shaded, rocky areas. Unlike other armadillos, they have sparse, yellowish fur, mainly on their bellies.

20–30 cm
8–12 in



ANDEAN HAIRY ARMADILLO

ChaetophRACTUS vellerosus

Unusual in having copious hair between its scales, this mammal inhabits high-altitude S. American grasslands. It is hunted for its meat and shell.

26–40 cm
10–16 in

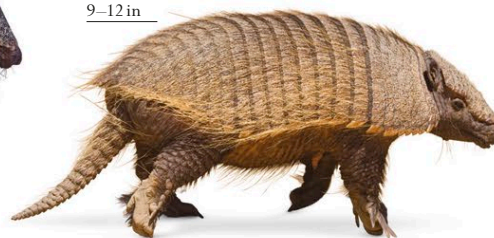


LARGE HAIRY ARMADILLO

ChaetophRACTUS villosus

From arid habitats in southern S. America, this species has long, coarse hairs between the 18 or so plates of protective armour across its back.

22–31 cm
9–12 in



PICHI

Zaedyus pichiy

A small, dark armadillo with thick dorsal plates, this species wedges itself into its burrow when threatened, presenting its jagged scales for defence.

40–50 cm
16–20 in



SIX-BANDED ARMADILLO

Euphractus sexcinctus

More active by day than most armadillos, this brownish-yellow species forages in grassland and forest, eating plant and animal matter.

11–15 cm
4½–6 in



PINK FAIRY ARMADILLO

Chlamyphorus truncatus

This tiny armadillo from C. Argentina is mainly subterranean, “swimming” through loose sand; its head is shielded to reduce abrasion.

30–38 cm
12–15 in

jointed bands on blackish upperparts



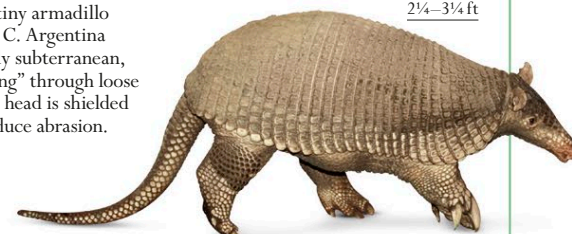
rounded, pink ears

NORTHERN NAKED-TAILED ARMADILLO

Cabassous centralis

The protective plates of this C. and S. American armadillo do not extend to its tail. It relies mainly on dense cover to avoid predators.

0.75–1 m
2¼–3¼ ft



GIANT ARMADILLO

Priodontes maximus

The largest armadillo, this species has tough armour and uses its long, curved third front claw to dig for food and in defence.